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To Whom It May Concern:

I am applying for the position of full-time researcher at Microsoft Research New England in Cambridge, Massachusetts. I expect to receive my Ph.D. degree from the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (UIUC) in Summer 2019, under the guidance of Prof. Dan Roth. My research interests are natural language processing (NLP) and machine learning.

The era of information explosion has opened up unprecedented opportunities to study the social, political, financial and medical events described in unstructured text. My Ph.D. research has focused on resolving the temporal implications for event understanding in natural language, on which I have published eight papers in top conferences such as ACL, EMNLP, NAACL, and ISIT. By leveraging structured learning, common sense acquisition, and a new crowdsourcing annotation scheme, my efforts on this topic culminated in improving the state-of-the-art of temporal relation extraction by more than 20% in absolute F1.

I strive to further push forward both (machine learning and linguistic) theories and applicability of NLP techniques to understand events expressed in natural language. I vision that the capability for computers to understand what is going on, what is the cause and impact, and how things will unfold over time, is not only the core of event understanding, but also crucial for bringing current NLP techniques to the next level. To achieve that ambition, I also think that a deeper understanding of how to learn from indirect signals is indispensable, which I have been and will continue to be excited about.

My academic excellence was recognized by the YEE fellowship at UIUC and the finalist for the best paper award at IEEE ISBI'15. I have taught two courses, Machine Learning and Introduction to Computing, for which I was recognized as "teachers ranked as excellent by their students" across the university and nominated for the Harold L. Olesen Teaching Award in the ECE department in 2016. I have also mentored 7 students who continued their excellence in top graduate schools. I believe I can build a successful career to lead cutting-edge research at Microsoft Research.

Thank you for your consideration. I eagerly look forward to hearing from you.

Yours sincerely,

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